

Still thinking on a good name

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April 29, 2026

Abstract

As the 2022-2026 administration of President Gustavo Petro approaches its end, the outcomes of Colombia's Política de Paz Total have become a matter of growing political and academic interest. One of the central promises of the Petro government was to reduce armed violence across the country by opening simultaneous peace talks and local negotiation processes with insurgent and criminal organizations. These processes sought to reduce confrontation, promote ceasefires, and create conditions for broader demobilization or negotiated settlement. Yet public debate and much of the existing qualitative assessment suggest that the policy has produced mixed and often disappointing results.

This thesis contributes to that debate by providing a quantitative analysis of subnational variation in violence during the implementation of Paz Total. It examines whether the onset of peace talks is associated with changes in monthly violent trends in three territorial cases: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco.

The analysis uses a panel dataset constructed from Colombian National Police records and ACLED event data, aggregating monthly observations of homicides, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, political violence, and demonstrations into a single measure of violent exposure. Methodologically, the thesis employs two-way fixed-effects models to estimate whether violence changes while peace talks are active, controlling for time-invariant territorial differences and common monthly shocks.

Keywords: Política de Paz Total, Colombia, Peace Process, Peacebuilding

1 Introduction

Violence in Colombia remains geographically uneven, organizationally fragmented, and historically persistent. Although the 2016 peace agreement with the FARC-EP marked a turning point in the country’s recent history, it did not produce a uniform transition to peace across the national territory. As Johnson et al. note, the agreement “marked a milestone in the country’s recent history” because it demobilized the most important armed group that represented the greatest threat to state control,” allowing “multiple regions of the country to experience peace after decades of absence” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author’s translation). Yet they also stress that, after the demobilization of the FARC, “some regions repeated cycles of violence” as other armed and criminal groups expanded their zones of control and dissident FARC factions emerged (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author’s translation).

In this sense, the post-2016 period should be understood less as a linear transition from war to peace than as a reconfiguration of armed order across territories with different institutional, political, and criminal structures. This interpretation is consistent with Pécaut’s long-run reading of the Colombian conflict, which emphasizes the exceptional continuity of armed organization and notes that the FARC maintained both “longevity” and “cohesion” even as Colombia underwent profound social and political transformations (Pécaut, 2008, pp. 23-24).

This persistence of violence is also evident in the broader national security context. Grasa observes that, six years after the 2016 agreement, the International Committee of the Red Cross still recognized six non-international armed conflicts in Colombia, including confrontations between the state and irregular actors as well as conflicts among illegal armed organizations themselves (Grasa, 2022, p. 4, author’s translation). The diversity of violence in Colombia is therefore not reducible to one actor, one war, or one mechanism of coercion. It includes insurgent conflict, criminal governance, extortion, targeted killings, territorial disputes, forced displacement, confinement, child recruitment, and persistent violence against civilians and community leaders.

In the classic formulation of *Nuestra guerra sin nombre*, the Colombian conflict resists simple dichotomies, since it is simultaneously more local and more global, and cannot be reduced to rigid categories such as political versus criminal violence (Gutiérrez Sanín and Sánchez Gómez, 2006, pp. 8-10). More recent work by Valencia and Serrano reaches a similar conclusion: the current

cycle of violence is marked by fragmentation, subnationalization, and the increasing importance of localized interactions among armed actors rather than a single national logic of war (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 141-145).

In this context Petro's government inherited a country marked by rising humanitarian impacts, including the highest recent levels of forced displacement and confinement, continued killings of social leaders, and an increase in homicide after a long period of decline at the national level (FIP, 2023, p. 5, author's translation). Colombia's current violent landscape is thus not only severe, but also regionally differentiated and shaped by multiple armed actors whose logics of control vary across territory. It was in this context that the government of Gustavo Petro adopted the *Política de Paz Total* (PPT).

The policy sought to negotiate simultaneously with a broad range of actors, including insurgent organizations and criminal groups, under an ambitious and territorially expansive peace agenda. The most thorough research initiative has been done by Johnson et al. (2025) from the SOCACE (Serious Organised Crime & Anti-corruption Evidence Research programme) with sponsor from Global Initiative Against Transnational Crime and CORE Foundation. The authors have been following the policy since it was first implemented, and they describe this new approach as one that "promotes simultaneous negotiations with criminal organizations and political armed groups in order to establish a complete peace" (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author's translation). Johnson's articles and other evaluation initiatives tend to conclude that the policy is either a failure or its impact is heavily limited.

This is aligned with Valencia and Serrano reinforce this point by arguing that, in the contemporary conflict, "ideology gave way to a much more pragmatic vision of the country, its regions, and war," so that cooperation and confrontation among armed actors are now better explained by territorial trajectories, material resources, and local alliances than by ideological commitments alone (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 41-42, author's translation). At the same time, they warn that this de-ideologization does not imply a purely criminal war, since many supposedly criminal actors remain political insofar as they govern territories, regulate civilians, and intervene in local democratic life (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 42-43). The ambition of Paz Total is therefore precisely what makes it both politically important and analytically difficult: it seeks to transform violent order across territories where armed governance takes very different forms. And hence, Paz

Total requires “an integral and multi-actor approach,” one that combines the reduction of direct violence through negotiated agreements with broader peacebuilding efforts aimed at structural causes of violence (Grasa, 2022, p. 1, author’s translation).

Jonhson from CORE stand at the position where the policy impact results are limited (Johnson, 2024; Johnson et. al 2025), which aligns with different reports that show some overall decreases in violence across cities like Buenaventura (FIP, 2024). However, these results are contrasted with evidence that portrays increased violence across the entire country (Ambos, 2026; Preciado, 2026) and the later report from FIP that also showcases how the violence has aggravated during 2025 and 2026 (Cajiao, 2026). In general, research sources point towards limited effects to the policy and even missing instruments for proper impact measurement (Valencia, 2025)

In general, the policy can be heavily analyzed from different sources. Some of the most thorough work comes from InSight Crime, that has an entire series focusing on the milestones of the policy from a journalistic position (see Insight Crime, Series Especiales: Dificultades y Desafíos de la Paz Total en Colombia <https://insightcrime.org/es/noticias/series-especiales/dificultades-desafios-paz-total-colombia/>), or the Fundación Ideas para la Paz interactive dashboard, where all the relevant milestones are summarized in a chess table (see FIP, Las Jugadas de la Paz Total <https://multimedia.ideaspaz.org/es/total/index.html>). And even, the policy can be analyzed at the yearly reports of Petro’s presidency from the FIP, where initially expectations seemed to be fairly positive, but on the latest reports the results are lukewarm at most (FIP, 2023; FIP, 2024; FIP, 2025). Some journalistic approaches are less compassionate, and they label the policy as a failure (Leon, 2026; FIP, 2026) and even, follow recent declarations from the same Gustavo Petro (Swissinfo, 2026). Overall, the panorama does not seem great. However, the assessments are merely qualitative or use only descriptive statistics. They assess the impact from interviews and people’s perspectives, or just describe the latest trends compared in a year to year basis, that does not allow a further comprehension of the real impact of the policy.

This thesis henceforth begins from a comparative perspective from the results of Johnson’s et. al. (2025), and uses the same units of analysis in pursue of an added quantitative approach to either reject or support their conclusions. For this reason, the document focuses on three territories: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco. Buenaventura, Colombia’s main Pacific port, is an urban setting marked by criminal governance, extortion, and territorial rivalry between Los Shottas and Los

Espartanos. Arauca, an eastern border department, has a long history of insurgent organization, particularly through the ELN's Frente Domingo Laín, and is shaped by broader regional dynamics linked to the Venezuelan border, oil rents, and inter-group confrontation. Whereas Tumaco, located on the southwestern Pacific coast in Nariño, is embedded in coca-growing corridors, riverine routes, and fragmented armed orders associated with FARC dissident structures and the Segunda Marquetalia. The qualitative results, should provide a base and a mechanism that helps understand changes in data. For example, the fall of homicides in Buenaventura after the ceasefire of Los Shottas and Los Espartanos is explained in the article, while it is also pointed out that the violent mechanism has shifted from homicides and shootings to forced disappearance.

In the same article, it is exposed that the killing of one of the gang leaders son starts a clash from both gangs, which pushes an increase in the homicides during 2023 even with active negotiations. This hence, will affect the final model and the trends that are inserted into the two way fixed effect, and for which the control for clash is inserted. On the same line, Arauca's case is also qualitatively explained. Even with active negotiations, the incursion of other groups into the area since 2022 and an expansionist leader on the FGO are pushing up the general observations of violent crimes. Hence, the change in violent trends, will likely be minimal or positive.

The initiation of the negotiation has shifted the local ordinance of the territory and hence increased the violent outcomes of the conflict, which affects the dependent variable from the territorial control mechanism. This said, not only the deeper comprehension of the territories from the qualitative level is relevant for this case. But, the difference of the governance mechanisms in the territories, the variety of Armed Groups and the difference in income sources provides a wider understanding of the different types of violence that are visible in Colombia, and allows to understand how the Política de Paz Total might have different outcomes depending on the nature of the criminal governance.

In this sense, Buenaventura represents the Urban Armed Groups. It is a very particular case, as not only it is the main port of the country, but it is a city greatly impacted by poverty and inequality (Valencia, 2016). The nature of Buenaventura conflict is very different from other places. As, the gangs fight for urban control, gather money from extorting and the sale of cocaine that is smuggled into the port or is sent to the north in semi-submersibles. In this sense, gangs are established as control entities inside the neighborhoods, but their control mechanisms are limited to these specific

areas. They are concentrated in the city, and the types of violence are more direct towards civilian population: homicides, extortion, civilian targeting, terrorism and even curfews (Sánchez-Garzoli, 2024)

Tumaco, on the other hand, is one of the main production and export clusters of cocaine in the country where the conflict between armed groups has been active since the 90's (Johnson, 2025). These groups are well established in the region, they depend mainly on cocaine and gold, and hence their actions shift based on their resource portfolio (Rettberg, 2016; Crisis Group, 2019). The strong presence and establishment allows the groups to control the territory without incurring in heavy violence. Although the clashes are permanent, the violent trends in the region are downgrading. Likely due to conflict stagnation and peace initiatives that are proliferating.

Something similar happens to Arauca. The well established ELN has received a military incursion from other groups since the initiation of peace talks with the government. ELN has presence on several departments, but their horizontal structure keeps them relatively separated from their counterparts in other regions (Aguilera, 2006). In Arauca ELN relies mostly on coca production, immigrant smuggling and oil. The groups has shown great interest in continuing a peace process, but internal fights, and clashes with other groups are giving varied results. It is not clear if the peace negotiations are reducing the violence in the region.

The variety of the cases will henceforth help understand the mechanism in different contexts of violence: a rebelocracy (Arjona, 2016) in the case of Arauca, as ELN has been present and taken over power from several years. Criminal Governance in Buenaventura, as Los Shottas and Espartanos are controlling, collecting taxes, defining geographical boundaries and punishing through different mechanisms as explained in Johnson (2025). And finally, the intermediate case of Tumaco, that is a criminal governance from a rebel group that has come to certain agreements with local authorities that would make it to some extent an aliocracy.

These cases are not treated as interchangeable. Rather, they are approached as territorially distinct expressions of Colombia's contemporary armed conflict, each shaped by a different configuration of governance, dispute, and spatial reach. Map 1 illustrates this first territorial distinction by locating the broader geography of armed spillovers and conflict dynamics in which the three cases are embedded. In line with Valencia and Serrano's argument that the contemporary Colombian war is increasingly subnational, the map shows that violence is not organized through a single national

conflict line, but through localized and regionalized patterns of dispute, coexistence, and dominance (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, pp. 44-45).

This perspective helps justify the spatial definition adopted in the thesis. Buenaventura is treated at the municipal level because the relevant armed order is concentrated in the urban port and its neighborhoods. Arauca is treated at the departmental scale because the armed dynamics associated with ELN governance and inter- group dispute extend beyond the municipality of Arauca and operate across a broader regional arena. Tumaco is treated as a regional cluster because its armed dynamics spill across adjacent municipalities connected by shared coca corridors, river mobility, and overlapping structures of armed control. Map 1 therefore supports the thesis's core spatial claim: peace-talk effects should be studied according to the territorial scope of armed governance rather than according to administrative units alone.

Map 2 complements this discussion by showing the territorial relationship between homicide rates and illicit economies, especially coca cultivation and cocaine seizures. While the national homicide rate may appear relatively stable in aggregate terms, the regional distribution of lethal violence is highly uneven. In 2024, departments such as Arauca, Cauca, Valle del Cauca, Putumayo, and Choco recorded some of the highest homicide rates in the country, concentrating violence in peripheral and border territories.

When these patterns are read together with the geography of illicit economies, a clearer territorial logic emerges: violence tends to cluster where armed actors compete for control over strategic corridors, rent-generating markets, and local populations. This is particularly visible in southwestern and Pacific regions, where coca cultivation, trafficking routes, and fragmented armed orders overlap.

Map 2 therefore does not merely describe a correlation between illegality and violence; it helps illustrate the political economy of territorial competition that underlies the persistence of armed conflict in places such as Tumaco and, in a different form, Arauca. Taken together, Maps 1 and 2 provide complementary justification for the case selection and spatial design of the thesis. Map 1 situates the three cases within broader patterns of armed spillover, regional dispute, and differentiated territorial governance. Map 2 shows that these same territories are also shaped by the spatial concentration of illicit economies, which increase their strategic value for armed actors and help sustain violent competition. The two maps thus reinforce the same analytical point from different angles: Colombia's contemporary war is territorially uneven, regionally interconnected, and deeply

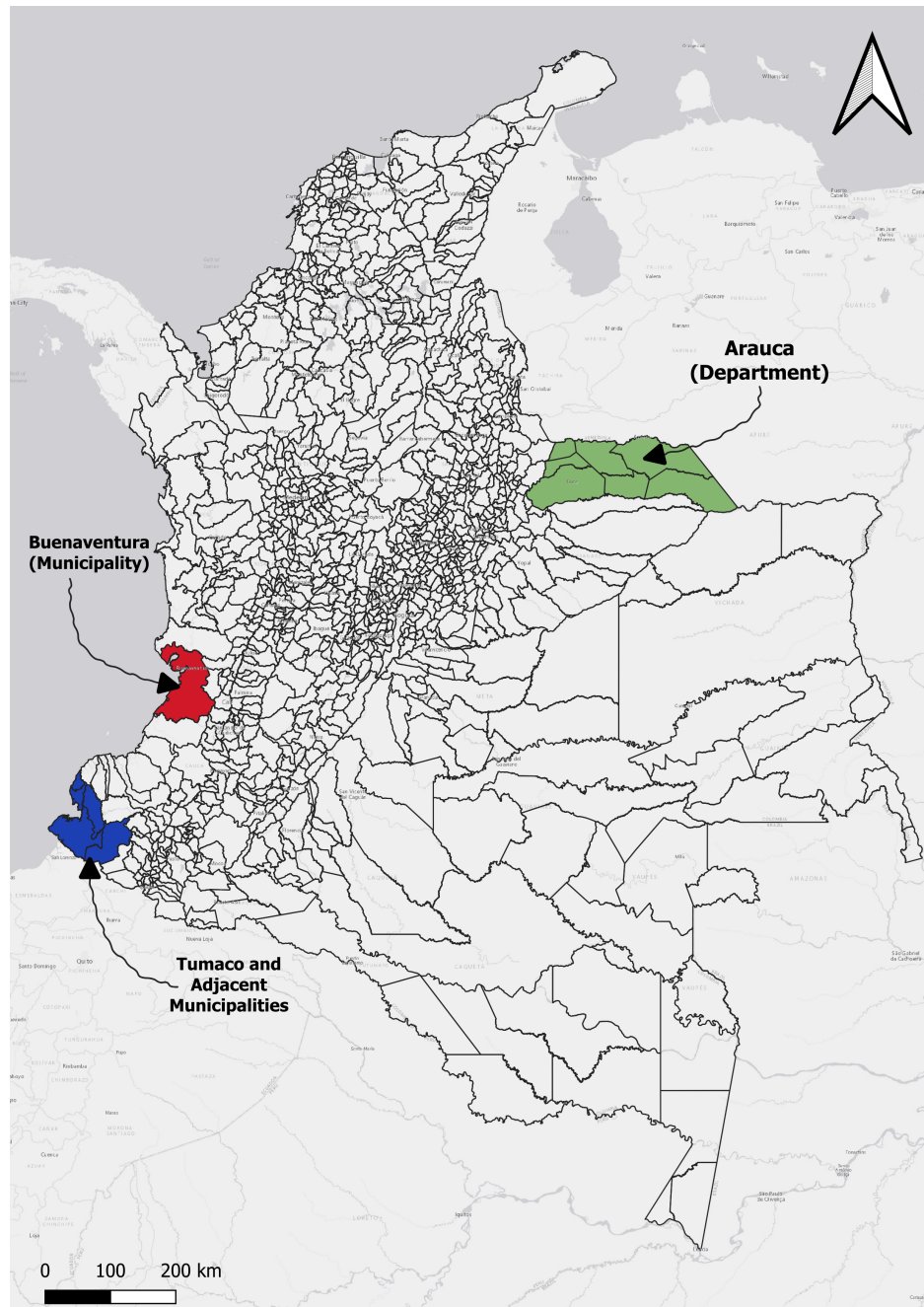


Figure 1: Selected areas for analysis. Source: Prepared by the author with ESRI basemap

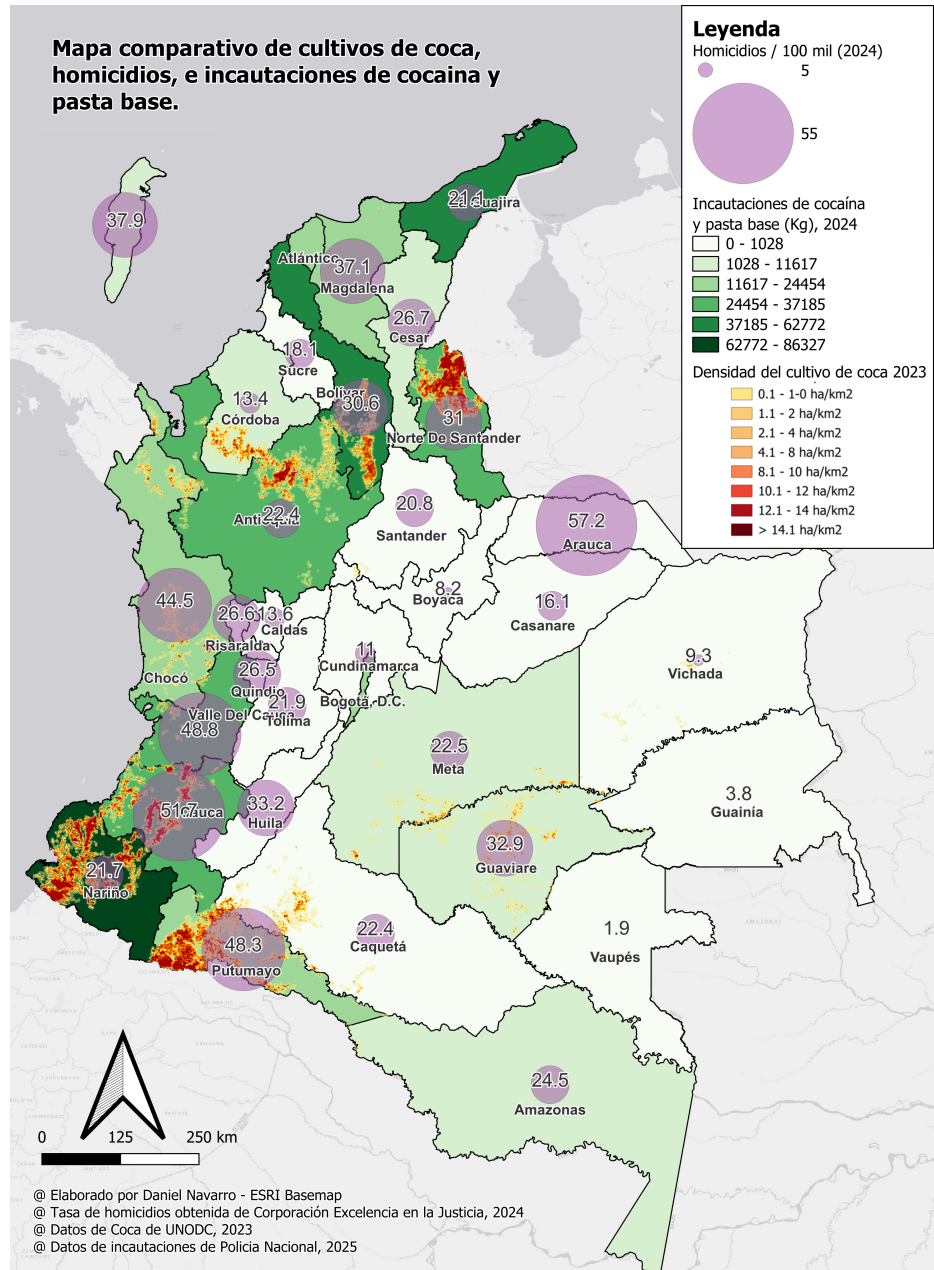


Figure 2: Cocaine, Seizures and Homicides National, Navarro and Valencia, 2025. Source: Prepared by the author and published on Valencia, 2025

linked to localized forms of armed governance and illegal accumulation.

For that reason, the effects of peace talks should be analyzed through territorially grounded case definitions rather than through a uniform national framework. The central research question is whether the onset of peace talks under Paz Total is associated with changes in monthly violent trends in these three cases. The main hypothesis is not that peace talks uniformly reduce violence. Rather, the argument is that negotiations may reconfigure violence, altering its level, territorial distribution, or observable forms depending on the local structure of armed governance.

This expectation follows from the broader theoretical claim that violence is both a mechanism of confrontation and an instrument of rule. Peace talks may reduce direct hostilities in some settings while enabling armed actors to consolidate extortion, regulate civilian life, or shift coercion into less visible forms in others. The empirical question, therefore, is whether negotiation periods are associated with observable changes in aggregate violent trends once each territory is compared against its own prior trajectory.

Methodologically, the thesis addresses this question using a monthly panel constructed from Colombian National Police and ACLED data. The outcome is an aggregate monthly count of violent observations, combining homicides, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting and political violence and into a single indicator of local exposure to coercion. This design allows the analysis to capture changes in the broader observable repertoire of violence rather than focus exclusively on one category such as homicide.

The empirical strategy relies on territorial-case and month fixed effects, so that each case is compared against itself over time while the model absorbs shocks common to all cases in a given month. The goal is not to produce a nationally generalizable estimate of the effects of Paz Total, but to assess whether peace talks are associated with shifts in violence in three substantively important and theoretically contrasting territories. The scope of the thesis is deliberately limited. It does not evaluate the entire national policy, nor does it attempt to explain every armed process opened under Paz Total.

Instead, it concentrates on three cases and on the observable violence recorded in police and ACLED sources. This implies several clear limits. First, the analysis cannot capture all forms of coercion equally well due to data limitations, and practices such as forced disappearance, forced recruitment, forced disappearance, massacres, and many forms of displacement fall out of scope.

This matters because these practices remain central to the contemporary Colombian war. Valencia and Serrano explicitly identify “child recruitment, confinements, and extortion” as part of the less visible effects of current violence (Valencia and Serrano, 2025, p. 143).

Second, the study relies on only three territorial units, which limits inferential power and requires cautious interpretation of fixed-effects estimates. Third, because Paz Total remains an ongoing and unfinished policy process, the findings should be understood as an assessment of changes during implementation rather than as a final evaluation of negotiated peace outcomes. The thesis therefore measures important observable dimensions of violence, but it does not claim to capture the full range of coercive practices through which armed actors govern territories and populations.

The remainder of the thesis proceeds as follows. Case selection will analyze the local implications and specificities of the chosen regions. The theoretical framework will argue that violence should be understood as an instrument of territorial control and governance and that the effects of peace talks depend on timing, sequencing, and local armed order. The research design, data, and empirical strategy, explaining the panel structure, treatment coding, and the logic of the two-way fixed-effects models. The following section will contain the exploratory data analysis and the main statistical results, with descriptive evidence that shows how Buenaventura and Tumaco experience declines in average violence during treatment months, whereas Arauca shows an increase. And finally the regression results.

2 Theoretical Framework

This thesis understands violence not simply as an episodic outcome of armed conflict, but as a mechanism through which armed groups govern territory, discipline populations, and manage competition. Johnson et al. (2025) state that “violence is the central factor for understanding how armed actors control and govern territories and local societies” (p. 23, author’s translation).

In that framework, violence is not limited to battlefield confrontation. It also includes coercive practices aimed at enforcing rules, punishing disobedience, and shaping local order. This logic is consistent with Arjona’s argument that “when armed groups control a territory and pursue long-term goals, they prefer to create rebelocracies. If they encounter a community that is likely to resist collectively, however, they are likely to limit their rule, establishing aliocracy instead” (Arjona, 2016,

pp. 100-101). It is also consistent with Masullo’s claim that civilian agency “can affect the level of violence that armed groups inflict on civilians. . . , the distribution of territorial control and the establishment of rebel governance” (Masullo, 2020, pp. 2-3). For this reason, homicide, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, and political violence are observable expressions of how armed actors compete, regulate, and govern.

The argument of this thesis is that peace talks may alter violent trends because negotiations change the strategic environment in which armed groups operate. Johnson et al. (2025) emphasize that “timing and sequencing are key factors in the development of dialogue processes” (p. 6, author’s translation). More specifically, they argue that “starting with a ceasefire and then negotiating and reaching an agreement is not the same as beginning with a ‘punishment or reward’ strategy (negotiating during war) and then silencing the guns” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 20, author’s translation). This insight is central to the causal mechanism of the thesis. Peace talks can reduce some forms of violence by lowering direct confrontation, signaling restraint, or stabilizing territorial boundaries. At the same time, they can increase or transform other forms of coercion if armed groups use negotiations to strengthen local rule, consolidate extortion markets, or regulate civilian behavior under reduced military pressure. As Johnson et al. (2025) conclude, “Total Peace opened a window of opportunity for the emergence, resurgence, or reconfiguration of rebel or criminal forms of governance” (p. 21, author’s translation). The hypothesis of changing violent trends therefore does not assume that peace talks automatically reduce violence; rather, it assumes that they can reconfigure its level, form, and territorial distribution.

In this framework, the count of events should be understood as an approximation of the scale of the problem rather than as a direct measure of the gravity of each act. Counting armed events, homicides, extortion, and related forms of violence captures the population’s exposure to coercive dynamics, even though each event is treated equally in the measurement strategy. The underlying argument is that a reduction in violence should be understood as a reduction across violent repertoires, rather than as a utilitarian exchange in which one violent mechanism is merely replaced by another. In Buenaventura, for example, the decline in homicides during the ceasefire between Los Shottas and Los Espartanos was reportedly accompanied by an increase in forced disappearances (Johnson et al., 2025). This cannot be interpreted as an improvement in the local security situation, although it is also an outcome that this study cannot fully capture. For that reason, the inclusion

of multiple categories of violence, treated as equally problematic indicators of coercion, allows for a broader assessment of the effects of the Total Peace policy. This expectation is especially strong in contexts where armed groups possess significant territorial control and differentiated forms of governance. Johnson et al. (2025) show that these forms vary sharply across the three study areas. In Arauca, “ELN governance is the most intense and extensive of the three cases” (p. 23, author’s translation), and later the report notes that “every aspect of peasant society was mediated and regulated by the ELN’s local structures” (p. 37, author’s translation). In Buenaventura, by contrast, Los Shottas and Los Espartanos “control the extortion market and security on cocaine trafficking routes, but do not intervene much more in the life of the local population” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 24, author’s translation), even though they maintain control over “the neighborhoods where they operated” (p. 33, author’s translation). Tumaco occupies an intermediate but regionalized position: armed regulation extends across “the region, including Tumaco, Barbacoas, Ricaurte and other municipalities” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 41, author’s translation), while “violence in the region did not cease; rather, it shifted to the municipalities north of Tumaco” (p. 44, author’s translation). These differences matter because, as Moreno León (2017) argues, “the reaction of armed actors toward demonstrations depends on both the target of those mobilizations and the level of control that armed actors exert over the territory” (p. 4). Violence should therefore be expected to respond differently to peace talks depending on whether negotiations occur in a fragmented criminal setting, a consolidated insurgent order, or a region where armed governance is expanding through pacts and territorial reorganization. The framework also implies that resource income conditions both governance and violence. In Arauca, Johnson et al. (2025) write that “the military strength of the FGO comes from its strong ties to the rural population [and] its considerable financial resources derived from extortion of the oil industry” (p. 35, author’s translation). In Tumaco, the report explains that armed actors were “motivated, mainly, by the income generated by their control over coca crops and illegal gold mines” (p. 43, author’s translation). These rents help armed organizations sustain coercion, reward followers, and survive negotiation cycles. For that reason, changes in violent trends during peace talks cannot be understood only as political effects; they must also be read in relation to the economic resources that sustain armed governance. Taken together, this literature supports that violence is a direct manifestation of territorial control, governance, and armed competition, and peace talks may change violent trends because they alter the timing, incentives, and sequencing of

coercion. In some settings, negotiations may reduce open violence by freezing conflict or clarifying spheres of control. In others, they may displace violence geographically or transform it into less visible but still coercive practices, such as extortion, civilian intimidation, or selective enforcement. The empirical question of the thesis is therefore not whether peace talks are inherently pacifying, but whether the onset of talks under the Total Peace policy is associated with a change in the level and composition of violence across regions characterized by different forms of armed governance.

3 Research Design

3.1 Research Question

Within Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco where peace negotiations were initiated under Petro’s ‘Total Peace’ policy (2022-2026), what is the association between the timing of those negotiations and the monthly incidence of conflict-related events (homicide, extortion, terrorism, civilian targeting, and political violence)?

Alternative Hypothesis (H1): The initiation of peace negotiations is associated with a statistically significant change in the monthly frequency of specific conflict-related crimes.

Null Hypothesis (H0): The initiation of formal peace talks in a municipality has no statistically significant association with the monthly frequency of specific conflict-related events.

Alternative Hypothesis 2 (H2): The initiation of peace negotiations is associated with a statistically significant positive change in frequency of specific conflict-related crimes.

3.2 Methodology and Variables

Methodologically, the study uses panel data and estimates two-way fixed-effects models. Two-way fixed models are a preferred tool as they enable us to address confounding biases that are unobservable but are common to all observed units (Dayal and Murugesan, 2023). In this case, the geographical level fixed effects account for unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity, while time fixed effects absorb time-varying (Dayal and Murugesan, 2023). Applied to this study, territorial-case fixed effects absorb time-invariant characteristics of each case, including geography, long-run armed-group presence, and local institutional structure, while month fixed effects absorb shocks common to all cases, such as macro-political changes, seasonality, and countrywide security dynamics. The

identifying logic is therefore within-case overtime comparison: the model tests whether violence changes once peace talks begin in a given case, net of permanent differences across territories and common shocks affecting all territories in the same month.

The panel-data is composed of Colombia’s violent trends across three subnational cases: Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco, measured as the monthly count of violent events. This choice treats event counts as an indicator of the frequency with which local populations are exposed to coercive practices. This is especially important in settings where peace talks may reduce one form of violence while displacing it into another. For that reason, the analysis uses an aggregate outcome and a disaggregated.

The disaggregated outcome is composed of 5 variables. Three of them, **homicides**, **terrorism**, and **extortion** come from police reports aggregated to the monthly level. Two additional variables come from ACLED and are likewise converted to monthly counts. **civilian_targeting** measures the monthly count of reported civilian targeting events. According to the ACLED dataset definition, civilian targeting includes violence against civilians events and explosions/remote violence events in which civilians were directly targeted. **political_violence** measures the monthly count of reported political violence events. In ACLED’s definition, political violence includes battles, violence against civilians, explosions/remote violence, and the mob violence sub-event type within riots. The set of variables are used as monthly counts of observed events rather than fatalities, and both are harmonized to the same case-month structure. Whereas, the aggregated variable is just the addition of these five components.

The mechanism of interest is whether the beginning of negotiations alters the strategic incentives of armed actors and is therefore associated with changes in the level of observed violence. As Johnson et al. argue, “timing and sequencing are key factors in the development of dialogue processes” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 6, author’s translation), and the implementation of *Paz Total* opened “a window of opportunity for the emergence, resurgence, or reconfiguration of rebel or criminal forms of governance” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 21, author’s translation). In the data, this mechanism is expressed as a change in monthly violent trends after the onset of peace talks relative to the pre-treatment period.

Violence is a mechanism of control. It includes coercive practices aimed at enforcing rules, punishing disobedience, and shaping local orders. This logic is consistent with Arjona’s argument that

“when armed groups control a territory and pursue long-term goals, they prefer to create rebelocracies” (Arjona, 2016, pp. 100-101), rebelocracies, are governments of armed groups whose foundations of govern come from terror and violent punishment. This is also consistent with Masullo’s claim that civilian agency “can affect the level of violence that armed groups inflict on civilians (...), the distribution of territorial control and the establishment of rebel governance” (Masullo, 2020, pp. 2-3). The selected variables are, therefore, observable expressions of how armed actors compete, regulate, and govern.

The main explanatory variable is **treatment**, a binary indicator coded as 1 during the months in which peace talks or formal negotiation processes were active in a given territorial case, and 0 otherwise. The treatment is not defined as a final agreement, a ceasefire outcome, or a successful demobilization, but rather as the period during which negotiations were underway under the framework of *Política de Paz Total*, or based on the armed group agreeing to begin the negotiations and had started reducing military actions even if the table hadn’t officially begun.

The coding of treatment periods relies primarily on Johnson et al. (2025), and news portals. In Arauca, the treatment begins in August 2022, when negotiations with the ELN resumed under the Petro administration (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 35), and is coded as ending in September 2024, when the process was suspended following the ELN attack on a military base in Arauca (*El Colombiano*, 2024). In Tumaco, the treatment begins in June 2024, when formal talks with the Segunda Marquetalia began and included the operational units in Tumaco (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 43). The treatment remains active through the end of the observed period because subsequent public reporting indicates continued dialogue with successor structures linked to that process (*El País*, 2025; *La Silla Vacía*, 2025). In Buenaventura, the treatment begins in September 2022, following the initiation of the preliminary negotiation phase between Los Shottas and Los Espartanos under the broader *Paz Total* framework (Johnson et al., 2025, pp. 29–30).

A central extension of the baseline design is the inclusion of time-varying control for armed-group dispute. The variable Clash is coded as a binary indicator equal to 1 in months in which a territorial case is experiencing active inter-group conflict and 0 otherwise. This control is included because changes in violence may reflect not only negotiation dynamics but also shifts in territorial confrontation among armed organizations. In substantive terms, control is especially important for Arauca, where violence rises in the context of an intensifying dispute beginning in January 2022

(Celis, 2026), and for Buenaventura, where the intensity of confrontation changes across periods of conflict and truce (SAGA UNODC, 2024; Reynoso, 2025; RTVC, 2025). Tumaco is coded as exposed to persistent inter-group conflict throughout the observed period. Including this variable helps separate the association between peace talks and violence from the association between violence and active armed dispute.

The study adopts a case-based territorial panel rather than a nationally pooled design because the relevant variation is local and because the territorial scale of armed governance differs across cases. This is based on two facts, one is the policy design itself, the Total Peace Policy “focuses on how local governance dynamics influence the implementation of Total Peace and highlights how they differ according to the local conditions of each region” (Johnson et al., 2025, p. 7, author’s translation). And second, as Colombia cannot be studied as a homogeneous region. The country is composed by several regions, that are built as oppositions of the "center". These, are a complex puzzle that has unique ways of governance, crime and even culture (Serge, 2006).

Accordingly, the unit of analysis is a territorial case-month. Buenaventura is modeled as a municipality-level case because criminal control is concentrated within the city (Insight Crime, 2025). Arauca is modeled at the departmental scale because the relevant armed order extends across the department and is shaped primarily by the Frente Domingo Laín (Insight Crime, 2026). Tumaco is modeled as a regional cluster because armed governance and violence spill across adjacent municipalities (Insight Crime, 2025b). This territorial definition is methodological rather than merely descriptive: it seeks to align the spatial scale of the data with the spatial scale at which armed control and negotiation effects are most likely to operate, and can be further inspected in 3.

Additionally, the design includes a time-varying control for armed-group dispute. The variable Clash is coded as a binary indicator equal to 1 in months in which a territorial case is experiencing active inter-group conflict and 0 otherwise. This control is included because changes in violence may reflect not only negotiation dynamics but also shifts in territorial confrontation among armed organizations. In substantive terms, control is especially important for Arauca, where violence rises in the context of an intensifying dispute beginning in January 2022 (Celis, 2026), and for Buenaventura, where the intensity of confrontation changes across periods of conflict and truce (SAGA UNODC, 2024; Reynoso, 2025; RTVC, 2025). Tumaco is coded as exposed to persistent inter-group conflict throughout the observed period. Including this variable helps distinguish the

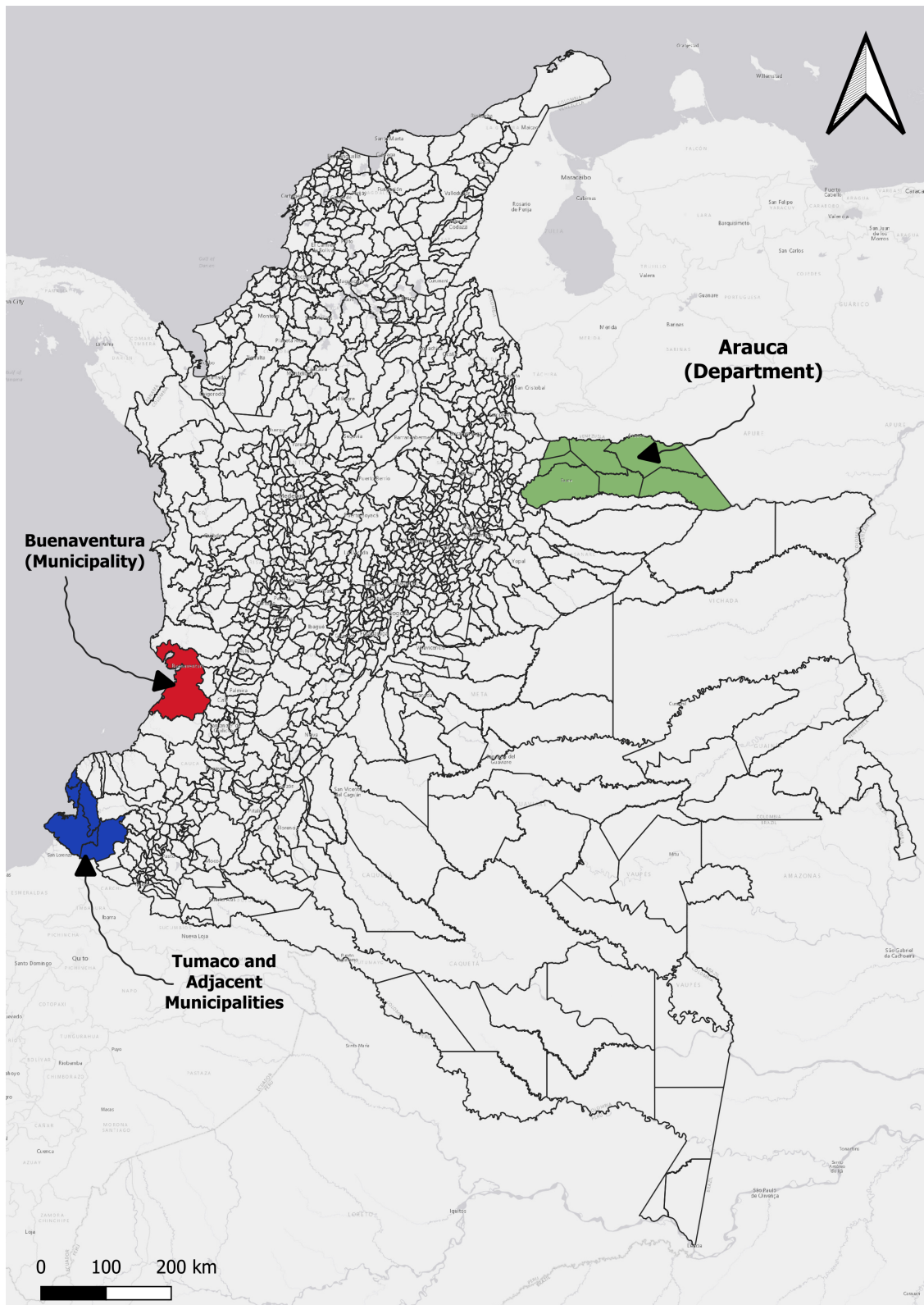


Figure 3: Colombia's map of treatment areas. Made by the Author with ESRI basemap

association between peace talks and violence from the association between violence and active armed dispute. More specifically, by adding an interaction term, the model can test whether the association of treatment differs between periods with and without clashes.

The baseline specification with this control is:

$$Violence_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t + \beta Treatment_{it} + \delta Clash_{it} + \theta (Treatment_{it} \times Clash_{it}) + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where $Violence_{it}$ is the monthly count of violent events in territorial unit i and month t , α_i are territorial-case fixed effects, λ_t are month fixed effects, $Treatment_{it}$ equals 1 in months in which peace talks are active in that case, and $Clash_{it}$ equals 1 in months with active armed-group dispute. In this specification, β captures the association between peace talks and monthly violence in case-months without active dispute, conditional on both fixed effects. The coefficient δ captures the association between active armed dispute and violence in non-treatment months, net of negotiations and fixed effects. The interaction coefficient, θ , captures the additional association when peace talks and active armed dispute occur simultaneously. In substantive terms, the interaction term allows the model to assess whether the association between treatment and violence differs between periods with and without clashes.

This design addresses the main sources of bias that fixed effects are intended to absorb. Armed governance, territorial control, and local institutional capacity are highly persistent over time and are therefore plausibly captured by territorial-case fixed effects. At the same time, common national developments, including changes in the broader implementation of *Paz Total*, military strategy, or macro-political shocks, are absorbed by month fixed effects. The inclusion of the armed-dispute dummy additionally accounts for a substantively important time-varying source of violence that would otherwise risk confounding the treatment effect. As a result, the empirical strategy isolates whether the negotiation period is associated with a deviation from the prior violent trend within each case, net of both enduring territorial characteristics and contemporaneous conflict dynamics. Standard errors are clustered at the territorial-case level, although inference must be interpreted cautiously given the small number of units. The design addresses the causal path as displayed in figure 1.

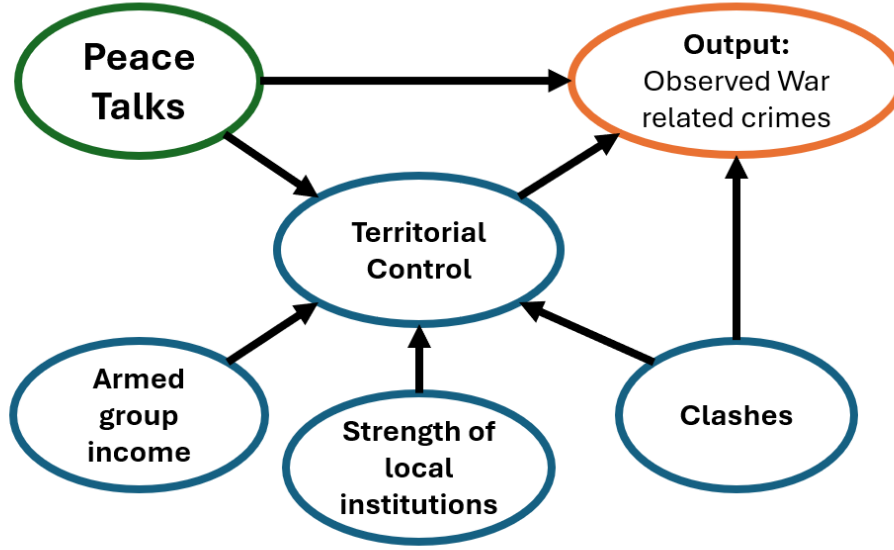


Figure 4: Causal Path: Peace Talks affect the Output (Observed War Related Crimes) and the territorial control. Territorial control affects the violent trends in the region, but mainly depends on the overall strength of the armed group, the civilian resistance and the clashes with other groups. Clashes, are affecting the outcome and the territorial control.

3.3 Assumptions

The first identifying assumption is that, conditional on territorial-case fixed effects, month fixed effects, and the inclusion of `clash_dummy`, there are no omitted case-specific time-varying shocks that both affect the onset of peace talks and independently alter violence in the same period. This is the key assumption that makes the treatment coefficient interpretable as a within-case association rather than a simple coincidence. It is plausible to the extent that the most important persistent differences across cases are absorbed by α_i , and the most important common shocks are absorbed by λ_t . The inclusion of `clash_dummy` strengthens this design by accounting for months in which active armed-group dispute is likely to affect violence independently of the negotiation process. However, the assumption would still be threatened if, for example, a major local security shock in one case simultaneously triggered negotiations and altered violence through a separate channel that is not fully captured by the observed clash measure.

A second assumption is limited anticipation. Armed actors should not systematically change their violent behavior long before the effective onset of peace talks in ways that would already embed

the treatment effect in the pre-treatment period. This is addressed by initiating the treatment period once the actors agreed to participate and acted accordingly, rather than when the negotiation table effectively begun.

A third assumption is that spillovers across the three territorial cases are limited enough not to invalidate the within-case comparison. This is addressed in the geographical specification. Moreno’s argument is useful here because he shows that armed actors’ responses depend on “the level of control that armed actors exert over the territory” (Moreno León, 2017, p. 4). If territorial control and violent responses shift across neighboring areas in direct response to negotiations, part of the observed effect may reflect displacement rather than a pure local treatment effect. Hence the importance of generating a regional cluster depending on the group’s presence.

Finally, the specification assumes that the treatment effect is modeled as an average additive shift during peace-talk months. This does not mean that the substantive process is simple. On the contrary, the theoretical framework suggests that negotiations may reduce some forms of violence but shifting to other under-reported ones such as forced disappearance. What the additive TWFE coefficient captures is the average change in aggregate monthly violence associated with the negotiation period, not the full complexity of all underlying mechanisms. In the same way, the inclusion of `clash_dummy` should not be interpreted as fully modeling the entire strategic structure of armed confrontation. Rather, it controls for one observable dimension of conflict intensity so that the treatment coefficient is less likely to absorb violent changes driven primarily by ongoing armed dispute.

This identification strategy is plausible for three main reasons. First, qualitative evidence suggests that the timing of peace talks was not determined solely by short-run local fluctuations in violence. Johnson et al. (2025) show that the onset of negotiations was shaped by a combination of national political windows, local security crises, and the willingness of armed groups to negotiate. In methodological terms, these sources of variation do not all threaten identification equally. National political windows, such as the launch and prioritization of the *Paz Total* policy, affected all cases and are therefore absorbed by month fixed effects. Local security crises are included in the design through the `clash_dummy`, limited to public information availability. Armed-group willingness to negotiate is more difficult to observe directly, but to the extent that it reflects durable organizational and territorial characteristics, much of it is captured by territorial-case fixed effects. For these

reasons, the timing of treatment is unlikely to be systematically driven by unobserved shocks that operate identically across all three cases.

Second, the potential role of armed-group income is compatible with the fixed-effects strategy. Gold and cocaine prices are determined in international markets and cannot plausibly be caused by the onset of peace talks in Buenaventura, Arauca, or Tumaco. In that sense, reverse causality from local negotiations to global prices is not a realistic concern. The more relevant question is whether changes in international prices may affect local violence and, indirectly, the strategic incentives surrounding negotiations. This is theoretically possible. However, because these price series are common to all cases within each month, their confounding role is addressed through month fixed effects in the baseline model.

Third, the fixed-effects design is well suited to the main confounders identified in the literature on Colombian armed conflict. Persistent differences in institutional quality, state presence, territorial control, and local social organization are central to explaining violent variation across territories. Arjona (2016) shows that local institutional strength shapes how armed actors govern and how communities resist them, while Gutiérrez Sanín and Barón (2006) emphasize the importance of territorial control and armed order in structuring violent dynamics. These are precisely the types of factors that are likely to remain relatively stable within a territorial case over the study period and are therefore absorbed by α_i , the territorial-case fixed effects. Likewise, broader policy changes and common national shocks are absorbed by λ_t , the month fixed effects. In this setting, the empirical strategy therefore isolates whether violence changes within a case once peace talks are underway, net of permanent territorial differences, common monthly shocks, and the observed timing of active armed-group dispute.

At the same time, the design is not free from threats. One possible concern is omitted variable bias from local shocks that coincide with the negotiation period and independently affect violence. This risk is especially relevant in highly localized and fluid urban settings such as Buenaventura, where short-run shifts in gang organization, neighborhood-level competition, or enforcement practices may alter violent trends independently of the talks. The inclusion of `clash_dummy` helps address this concern, but it cannot eliminate it completely because not every local shock takes the form of an observable clash period. Tumaco is permanently exposed to clash as this violent dynamics are constant and under-reported. The risk may be lower in Arauca, where armed governance is

more territorially consolidated, but it cannot be ruled out.

For these reasons, the two-way fixed-effects model should not be understood as proving exogeneity, nor as fully eliminating all threats to causal inference. Rather, it makes the identifying assumption more plausible by accounting for the most important sources of confounding highlighted in both the substantive and methodological literature. The resulting estimates should therefore be interpreted as theoretically informed within-case comparisons over time. They provide credible evidence on whether violent trends changed during the period in which peace talks were active, while still requiring caution about local omitted shocks, treatment timing, spillovers, and the very small number of territorial cases.

4 Exploratory Data Analysis

The monthly panel contains 297 territorial case-month observations from January 2018 to March 2026. Across the full sample, the average monthly count of total events is 31.074, with substantial variation over time and across cases ($sd = 22.735$; $min = 0$; $max = 137$). This already suggests that violence is not distributed evenly across Buenaventura, Arauca, and Tumaco.

Table 1: Table 1: Small descriptive table with treatment timing by case.

Case	mean	sd	min	max	t begin	pre t months	t months
Arauca Department	52.414	21.745	5.000	137.000	2022-10-01	76.000	23.000
Buenaventura	26.182	13.692	0.000	66.000	2023-08-01	70.000	29.000
Tumaco Region	14.626	11.976	0.000	64.000	2024-06-01	78.000	21.000

Table 1 shows these baseline differences more clearly. Arauca has the highest average level of monthly violence, at 52.414 events, and also the highest maximum, at 137. Buenaventura is lower, with an average of 26.182 monthly events, while Tumaco has the lowest mean, at 14.626. Treatment timing also differs across cases. In the current coding, peace talks begin in October 2022 in Arauca, August 2023 in Buenaventura, and June 2024 in Tumaco, corresponding to 23, 29, and 21 treatment months, respectively. These differences matter because the three cases do not enter the negotiation period from the same baseline level of violence.

Table 2 compares pre-treatment, treatment-period, and clash-status means by case. The descriptive pattern is not uniform across territories. Buenaventura shows a small decline in average monthly violence during treatment months, from 26.957 to 24.310, and Tumaco shows a larger de-

Table 2: Table 2: Pre-treatment, treatment-period, and clash-status means by case.

Case	pre t	t	diff	no clash	clash	clash diff
Buenaventura	26.957	24.310	-2.647	20.446	37.147	16.701
Arauca Department	50.224	59.652	9.428	49.875	54.804	4.929
Tumaco Region	17.410	4.286	-13.125		14.626	

cline, from 17.410 to 4.286. Arauca moves in the opposite direction, increasing from 50.224 before treatment to 59.652 during treatment. At the descriptive level, this suggests that peace talks are not associated with one common direction of change across all three cases.

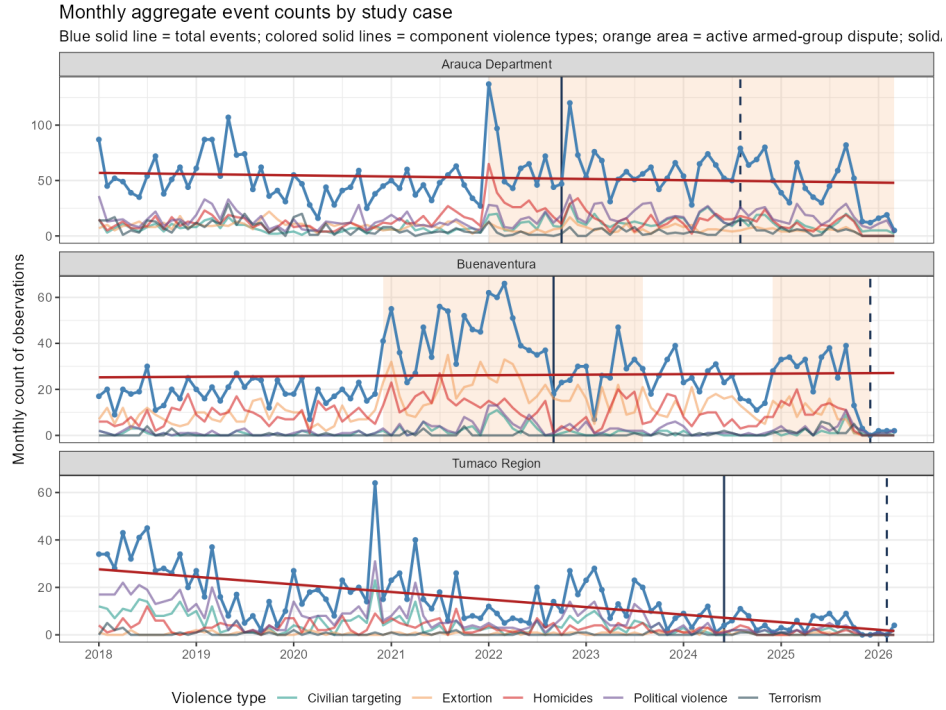


Figure 5: Observations of each type of event across the regions

Clash status adds an important qualification. In Buenaventura, average monthly violence is much higher in clash-active months than in clash-inactive months, increasing from 20.446 to 37.147 events. In Arauca, the same comparison is also positive, rising from 49.875 to 54.804. In Tumaco, `clash_dummy` equals 1 in all observed months, so there is no within-case comparison between clash-active and clash-inactive periods. Overall, the descriptive evidence suggests that variation in violence is closely linked to active dispute, and that treatment timing alone should be interpreted cautiously before turning to the regression models. Furthermore, by analyzing 5 it can be seen that the trends are different across each territory, and in most cases how the lines move whenever the

clashes begin. These differences help address better the impact of the policy across heterogeneous cases.

Taken together, the exploratory evidence suggests that the relationship between peace talks and violence is highly context-specific. The descriptive results do not support a single common pattern across the three study areas. Rather, they point to divergent trajectories that should be interpreted in light of different forms of armed governance, territorial control, and active dispute.

5 Results

Across the models, the main question is whether the timing of peace talks is systematically related to aggregate violence and to specific forms of violence. Overall, the results provide only limited support for **H1**. The strongest and most consistent pattern is not the effect of peace talks themselves, but the positive association between active armed-group dispute and higher violence.

Table 3 presents pooled OLS estimates for aggregate violence. In the models without interaction, the treatment coefficient is not statistically significant. In the interaction model, the association between peace talks and violence appears to differ depending on whether clashes are active. The treatment coefficient is negative in non-clash months, while the positive interaction term indicates that this negative association becomes smaller when clashes are active. However, pooled specifications do not account for structural differences across regions, so these results should be treated only as descriptive baseline evidence.

Table 4 introduces case fixed effects, which makes the comparison more appropriate by absorbing time-invariant differences across the three territories. In these models, peace talks are negatively associated with aggregate violence once clash control is included, but this relationship weakens when the interaction is added. At the same time, active armed-group dispute remains large and positive. This suggests that part of the observed change in violence is better explained by whether clashes are taking place than by the onset of negotiations alone.

3.5pt

Then, table 5 provides the preferred aggregate specifications because it includes both case and month fixed effects. In the standard TWFE models, peace talks are not statistically significant, while clash activity remains strongly and consistently associated with more violence. The interac-

Table 3: Pooled OLS: effect of peace talks on aggregate monthly event counts

	(1) Pooled		
treat. only	(2) + active		
dispute	(3) + treat.×		
dispute			
Constant	31.53***	33.12***	34.51***
	(1.52)	(2.19)	(2.30)
Peace talks active	−1.84	−1.24	−11.01*
	(3.07)	(3.12)	(6.12)
Active armed-group dispute		−2.81	−5.25*
		(2.77)	(3.06)
Peace talks × active dispute			13.17*
			(7.10)
R ²	0.00	0.00	0.02
Adj. R ²	−0.00	−0.00	0.01
Num. obs.	297	297	297

Standard errors in parentheses.

Col. (3): Peace talks, active armed-group dispute, and treat.×dispute.

Table 4: Case fixed effects: effect of peace talks on aggregate monthly event counts

	(1) Case FE		
treat. only	(2) + active		
dispute	(3) + treat.×		
dispute			
Peace talks active	−1.92	−5.04**	1.28
	(2.21)	(2.22)	(4.39)
Active armed-group dispute		12.03***	13.69***
		(2.39)	(2.58)
Peace talks × active dispute			−8.50*
			(5.11)
Num. obs.	297	297	297
Num. groups: case_id	3	3	3
R ² (full model)	0.49	0.53	0.53
R ² (proj model)	0.00	0.08	0.09
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.48	0.52	0.52
Adj. R ² (proj model)	−0.00	0.08	0.08

Standard errors in parentheses.

All columns include territorial-case fixed effects.

Col. (3): Adds peace talks × active armed-group dispute.

Table 5: Two-way fixed effects: effect of peace talks on aggregate monthly event counts

	(1) TWFE			
treat. only	(2) + active			
dispute	(3) + treat.×			
dispute	(4) By case			
+ interact.				
Peace talks active	4.30 (3.10)	2.91 (2.83)	10.61** (5.28)	
Active armed-group dispute		16.70*** (2.63)	18.78*** (2.88)	22.15*** (3.57)
Peace talks × active dispute			−9.20* (5.33)	
Peace talks (Buenaventura)				11.80** (5.31)
Peace talks (Arauca)				−6.03 (5.07)
Peace talks (Tumaco)				7.73 (5.02)
Peace talks × dispute (Buenaventura)				−5.28 (7.06)
Num. obs.	297	297	297	297
Num. groups: case_id	3	3	3	3
Num. groups: month_id	99	99	99	99
R ² (full model)	0.69	0.75	0.75	0.76
R ² (proj model)	0.01	0.18	0.19	0.21
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.54	0.61	0.62	0.62
Adj. R ² (proj model)	0.00	0.17	0.18	0.19

Standard errors in parentheses.

Cols. (1)–(3): Territorial-case and month fixed effects.

Col. (4): Case-specific peace talks and treat.×dispute.

Arauca/Tumaco interaction terms omitted when collinear; only Buenaventura treat.×dispute reported among interactions.

Table 6: TWFE models by violence outcome (peace talks, active dispute, and interaction)

violence targeting	Political Civilian	Homicides	Terrorism	Extortion	
Peace talks active	4.31** (2.02)	1.87 (1.39)	2.39 (2.21)	−0.24 (1.23)	2.29 (1.87)
Active armed-group dispute	7.43*** (1.10)	6.05*** (0.76)	4.42*** (1.20)	−0.97 (0.67)	1.85* (1.02)
Peace talks × active dispute	−5.10** (2.04)	−1.43 (1.40)	−0.80 (2.23)	0.56 (1.24)	−2.43 (1.89)
Num. obs.	297	297	297	297	297
Num. groups: case_id	3	3	3	3	3
Num. groups: month_id	99	99	99	99	99
R ² (full model)	0.73	0.70	0.64	0.59	0.67
R ² (proj model)	0.19	0.28	0.09	0.01	0.02
Adj. R ² (full model)	0.58	0.54	0.44	0.37	0.49
Adj. R ² (proj model)	0.18	0.26	0.07	−0.00	0.00

Standard errors in parentheses.

Each column is a separate violence outcome (monthly event counts).

All models include territorial-case and month fixed effects.

tion model shows that the association of peace talks may depend on whether clashes are active, but the addition of the interaction coefficient and the treatment coefficient suggests that either way, treatment will have an overall positive effect on violence. In substantive terms, the results are pointing towards an increase in violence whenever the treatment is implemented, however the magnitude is still uncertain, which allows to partially accept H2.

Now, the heterogeneous by-case specification should be interpreted cautiously. Only Buenaventura provides meaningful variation in both treatment status and clash status during the treatment period, which helps explain why only Buenaventura shows a statistically significant case-specific association, while Arauca and Tumaco do not. Further research should analyze cases where there is a clear reporting of clash periods on the region, or use cases with constant clashes such as Tumaco without the interaction term to provide a different perspective within the conflict.

Finally, table 6 breaks the analysis down by type of violence and provides a disaggregated answer. The most notable result appears for *political violence*, where peace talks are positively associated with incidents, but that association becomes weaker when clashes are active, as shown

by the negative interaction term. For civilian targeting, homicides, terrorism, and extortion, the treatment coefficients are generally imprecise and not statistically significant at conventional levels. This means that **H1** receives only partial support: the timing of negotiations is associated with some forms of violence, especially political violence, but not with a broad or consistent shift across all conflict-related outcomes.

In conclusion, the findings suggest that the relationship between peace negotiations and violence is conditional, outcome-specific, and heavily shaped by the presence of active armed dispute. The most precise model, Two-way fixed effects with interaction term allows to accept partially **H1**, as there is a statistical significance in the 10 percent range that the treatment is increasing the observed violence in the regions. With an active clash, the effect of the treatment is still positive. Which suggests, that aligned with the qualitative findings, the total peace policy could indeed be causally related to an overall increase on violent actions across the implementation regions which allows accepting **H2**.

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